

Bash Shortcuts

Move, edit, and recall on the command line without the arrow keys.

[GitHub ↗](#)

Move the Cursor

▼

These are Readline (Emacs-mode) key bindings — they work the same in Bash, Zsh, and most REPLs, on Linux and macOS. Learning even the top row (Ctrl-A, Ctrl-R, Ctrl-W) makes the shell dramatically faster.

MOVE THE CURSOR

KEYS	MOVES TO
Ctrl-A	start of the line
Ctrl-E	end of the line
Alt-B	back one word
Alt-F	forward one word
Ctrl-XX	toggle between start and current position

EDIT THE LINE

KEYS	DOES
Ctrl-W	delete the word before the cursor

KEYS	DOES
Ctrl-U	delete from cursor to start of line
Ctrl-K	delete from cursor to end of line
Ctrl-Y	paste (yank) what you just deleted
Alt-D	delete the word after the cursor
Ctrl-T	transpose (swap) the last two characters
Alt-U / Alt-L	uppercase / lowercase the next word
Ctrl-_	undo the last edit



Cut and paste, shell-style. Ctrl-U , Ctrl-K , and Ctrl-W don't just delete — they cut into a buffer. Ctrl-Y pastes it back, so you can move text around the line.

HISTORY

KEYS / TOKEN	DOES
Ctrl-R	reverse-search history (type to filter)
Ctrl-G	cancel the history search
Ctrl-P / Ctrl-N	previous / next command
Alt-.	insert the last argument of the previous command
!!	the entire previous command
!\$	the last argument of the previous command
!abc	the most recent command starting with abc

The classic sudo rescue

```
apt update          # oops, permission denied
sudo !!            # re-runs: sudo apt update
```

CONTROL THE SHELL

KEYS	DOES
Ctrl-C	interrupt the running command
Ctrl-D	end of input / log out of the shell
Ctrl-Z	suspend to the background (fg to resume)
Ctrl-L	clear the screen (same as clear)
Ctrl-S / Ctrl-Q	pause / resume terminal output